The Pursuit of Purushartha

A Path to Holistic and Purposeful Living

Purushartha is a key concept in Hinduism, referring to the four ultimate goals of human life. The term is derived from two Sanskrit roots; *purusha*, meaning "human being," and *artha*, meaning "purpose" or "objective." As such, purushartha can be translated as the “object of human pursuit” or “purpose of human beings.”

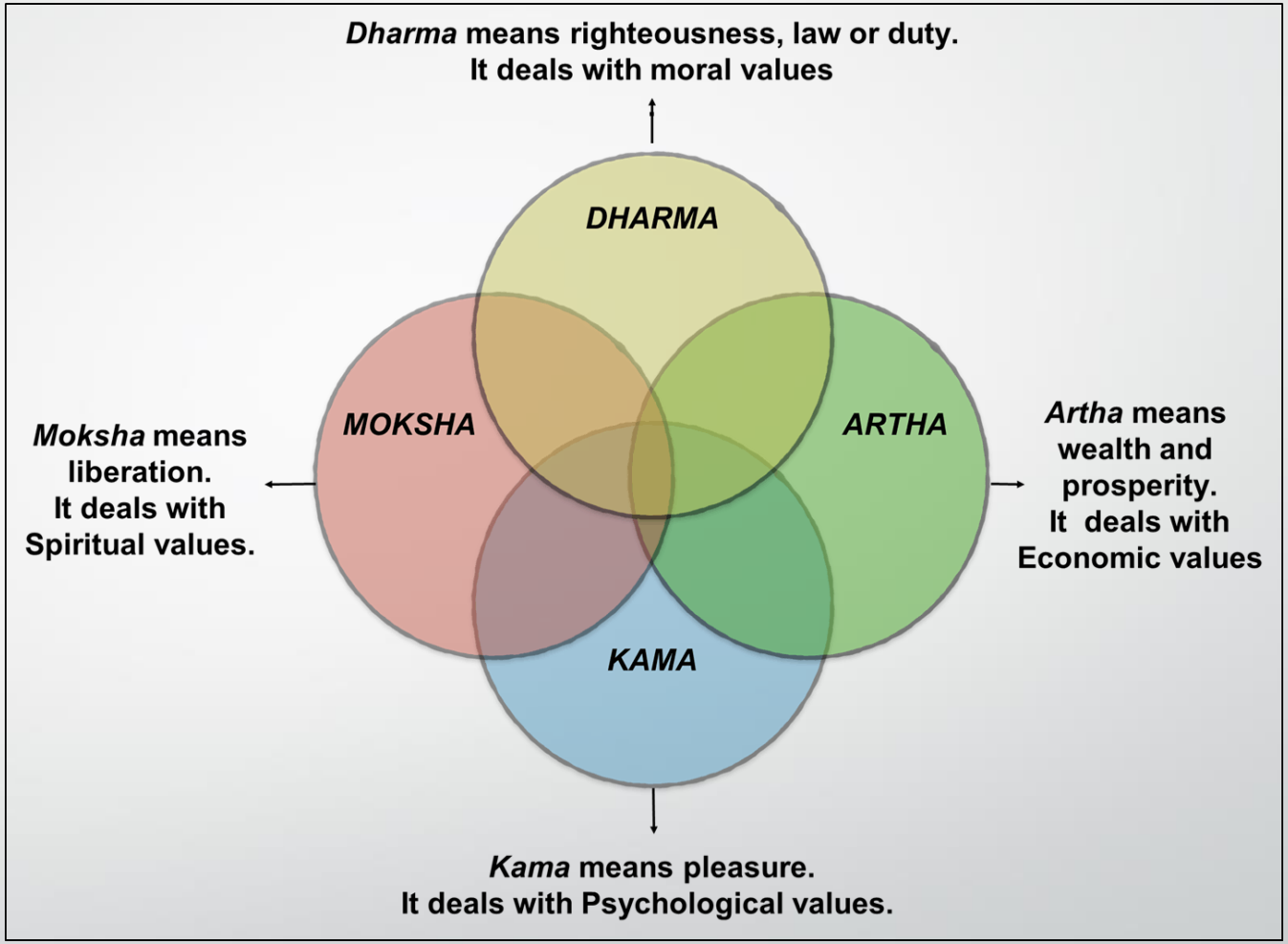
Arranged in order of priority from lowest to highest, the four purushartha are: a*rtha* (prosperity and economic values), *kama* (sensual pleasures), *dharma* (righteousness and morality), and *moksha* (liberation from the cycle of reincarnation).

Whilst all four of these goals are considered to be important, Hindu philosophy gives precedence to dharma over artha and kama, and moksha is viewed above all as the ultimate aim of all human life.

Purushartha may also sometimes be referred to as *caturvarga*.

The Four Pillars of Purushartha:

- Dharma (Righteousness, Duty)
- Artha (Wealth, Prosperity)
- Kama (Desires, Fulfillment)
- Moksha (Liberation, Spiritual Freedom)



Dharma – The Foundation of Life

- Dharma –The definition of Dharma encompasses a variety of interpretations across different texts and disciplines. According to Purana, it includes the guiding principles and duties designated by the Lord for various castes and life stages. Vyakarana highlights Dharma as moral obligation derived from the Vedas, emphasizing ethical behavior. Historical perspectives consider Dharma as embodying law, morality, righteousness, and societal duties.

- Types of Dharma:
- Sva-dharma (Personal duty). Types:

Varna-Ashrama Dharma (Duty based on life stage & profession):
Brahman, *Kshatriya*, *Vaishya* and *Shudra* are the four classes. *Dharma* applicable to the respective class is known as *Varnadharma.*
Ashrama Dharma:
Brahmacharyashram, Gruhasthashram, vanaprasthashram and *Sanyasashram* are the four *ashrams*.This dharma is limited to a particular stage of life.

- Samanya Dharma (Universal duty): *Samanyadharma* includes mercy, truth, control over the mind, purity, offerings, control over the senses, non-violence, service unto the Guru, pilgrimage, compassion, honesty, absence of greed, honouring Deities and *Brahmans* and not criticising anyone.
- Role in Life: Maintains harmony and justice
- Examples: Bhagavad Gita's concept of duty (Krishna-Arjuna dialogue)

Arjuna's Dilemma:
Arjuna, a warrior, is faced with the prospect of fighting his own kin, causing him great distress and confusion about his duty.
Krishna's Teachings:
Krishna, in response, explains the concept of dharma and urges Arjuna to fulfil his duty as a warrior, emphasizing that action is superior to inaction and that one should not be attached to the results of their actions.

In the Bhagavad Gita, Krishna's teachings to Arjuna, particularly emphasizing the concept of dharma (duty), illustrate how fulfilling one's role and acting without attachment to outcomes is crucial for righteousness and achieving one's purpose.

Artha – The Means to Stability

- Definition: Pursuit of Material well-being and economic security in a dharmic way.
- Significance: Necessary for a stable and fulfilling life
- Ethical Earning: Wealth must be acquired through just means
- Balancing Artha with Dharma: Example – King Harsha's generosity

King Harsha (Harshavardhana, 606–647 CE) is a great historical example of Artha in action. Although Harsha focused on Artha, he also upheld Dharma (duty and righteousness). He was a patron of Buddhism and Hinduism, supporting education, religious institutions, and welfare activities.Thus, King Harsha is an excellent historical example of a ruler who effectively pursued Artha while balancing it with Dharma, ensuring the prosperity and stability of his empire.

Kama – The Pursuit of Happiness

Kama Purushartha, according to Kamashastra, embodies human wellbeing and the gratification of desires contributing to a fulfilling life. It signifies an essential aspect of human existence within Ayurveda, emphasizing desire as crucial for overall happiness.

This includes sexual fulfilment and reproductive health, making Kama an integral part of the four Purusharthas that guide individuals toward a balanced and satisfying life.It highlights the importance of desire in personal and communal well-being.

In contemporary literature, *Kama* is often used to connote sexual desire and emotional longing, but the ancient concept is more expansive, and broadly refers to any desire, wish, passion, pleasure, or enjoyment of art and beauty, the aesthetic, enjoyment of life, affection, love and connection, and enjoyment of love with or without sexual connotations.

- Scope:
- Enjoyment of arts, relationships, and life's pleasures
- Should be pursued without harming oneself or others
- Balance with Dharma and Artha: Ensuring ethical pleasure

Example: Kalidasa’s depiction of love in classical literature:

Kalidasa’s poetry and dramas beautifully explore various shades of love—romantic, divine, and longing. His works highlight both the joys and sorrows of love, aligning with the concept of Kāma as an essential aspect of human life. His work, Abhijnana Shakuntalam (The Recognition of Shakuntala) is one of the finest examples of Kāma, portraying King Dushyanta’s love for Shakuntala. Their love evolves from passionate attraction to a deeper emotional and spiritual bond.The pangs of separation and ultimate reunion highlight the transformative power of love.

Moksha – The Ultimate Liberation

Moksha is the ultimate goal in Hindu, Jain, and Buddhist philosophies, representing liberation, freedom, or spiritual enlightenment. It is the state of being free from the cycle of birth and death (samsara) and transcending all worldly attachments and sufferings.

Key Aspects of Moksha:

1. Liberation from Samsara – Release from the continuous cycle of birth, death, and rebirth.
2. Freedom from Karma – Transcending the effects of past actions and desires.
3. Union with the Divine – Attaining oneness with Brahman (in Vedanta) or realizing the pure soul (in Jainism).
4. State of Ultimate Bliss – A state of eternal peace, knowledge, and joy beyond material existence.

Moksha in Different Philosophical Traditions:

- Hinduism – Self-realization and merging with Brahman (Advaita) or eternal service to God (Bhakti schools).
- Buddhism – Nirvana, the cessation of suffering and desires.
- Jainism – Kevala Jnana (pure knowledge), leading to complete freedom from karma.

Moksha is often pursued through Jnana (wisdom), Bhakti (devotion), Karma (righteous action), and Dhyana (meditation), depending on the philosophical path one follows.

Example:
Adi Shankaracharya (8th century CE), the great proponent of Advaita Vedanta, taught that Moksha (liberation) is attained through self-realization, where one realizes the identity of the individual soul (Atman) with the ultimate reality (Brahman). One of his most famous teachings states: “Brahma Satyam, jagat mithya, jivo brahmaiva naparah.”(“Brahman is the only reality, the world is an illusion, and the individual soul is not different from Brahman.”)